

long spoken out in defense of slavery. He actually hoped that the Republicans would win the election, since this would force Southerners to “choose between secession and submission to abolition domination.”

The Democrats divided

In late April 1860, the Democrats gathered in Charleston, South Carolina, to nominate their candidate. They could not have chosen to meet in a more polarized city. Street orators called for disunion, while fire-eaters among the Southern delegates openly scorned Senator Stephen A. Douglas and his Northern supporters. At a certain point, the Northern majority reaffirmed its support for popular sovereignty, which allowed the local voters to determine the legality of slavery in the territories. In reaction to this, Southern delegates stormed from the hall.

After 57 failed ballots and a hasty compromise, the convention was rescheduled for June in Baltimore, Maryland, but radical Southerners again disrupted the proceedings and marched out. While the remaining Democrats nominated Stephen A. Douglas, the Democrats of the Deep South and their allies reconvened in Richmond, where they chose Vice President John Breckinridge as their candidate for president.